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GEOGRAPHICAL RECORD

CONSTRUCTING AND NATURALIZING THE MIDDLE EAST

KAREN CULCASI

I have been writing about it in the *Guardian* for almost four years and I'm fairly sure that I have been there, but I have to confess that I don't know for certain where the Middle East is.

—Brian Whitaker, 2004

Defining or locating the “Middle East” is a precarious endeavor.¹ The territory and the characteristics that have been used to delimit and describe this world region have varied immensely over time and space. Even a cursory examination of maps or encyclopedias quickly reveals that the Middle East and the various criteria that have been used to define it are variable and ambiguous. Nevertheless, the region has been naturalized as a real and definable place. Indeed, popular and political discourses on the Middle East are so commonplace that we rarely scrutinize their socially constructed origins and connotations.

Critical examinations of naturalized geographical concepts such as “space,” “scale,” and “place-specific identities” have sparked vibrant discussions (Häkli 1998; van Schendel 2002, 659), but the world region has received scant attention. Generally defined as groupings of contiguous states that have some cultural, historical, economic, and even physiographic similarity, world regions are a taken-for-granted concept (N. Smith 1992, 64–78; Lewis and Wigen 1997, 13; Harvey 2001, 224). However, world regions are not naturally existing, homogeneous spaces; rather, they are social constructs that are formed and altered in a myriad of discourses (Murphy 1997, 256; Paasi 2001, 13, 16; Hagen 2003). In this essay I analyze the construction and naturalization of the Middle East as a world region. Specifically, I provide a comprehensive and critical examination of the origins, definitions, delineations, and meanings of “Middle East” that have been formative in incorporating this place in our everyday geographies. My goal is to move beyond questions such as “What is the proper designation of the Middle East?” “What is its actual extent?” and “What criteria best determine the region’s name and limits?” (Held 2005, 7), in order to show that the Middle East—and world regions more generally—is not a naturally existing place waiting to be defined, labeled, and described but a discursive construct that is enmeshed in a variety of power relationships.

ORIENTALISM AND THE MIDDLE EAST

The construction of the Middle East is deeply embedded in Orientalist discourses. In his seminal book *Orientalism*, Edward Said argued that, since early European

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explorations, “Westerners” have imagined the “Orient” and its inhabitants as timeless, backward, violent, and inferior (1978, 54–55). These geographical imaginings of the Orient were pivotal in constructing the Other as inherently different from “us.” Once established as different and inferior, Western domination of these Other peoples and places was not merely justified but also warranted. Although imaginings of the backward, violent, and inferior Other have been altered slightly since the early nineteenth century, as Douglas Little argued in *American Orientalism: The United States and the Middle East since 1945* (2002), they have survived and are now deeply ingrained in everyday American life. Today, however, the terminology has changed from the “Orient” to the “Middle East.”

As we perceive the Orient, so too do we often perceive the Middle East in negative and particularistic contexts, such as terrorism, instability, violence, Islamic fundamentalism, anti-Americanism, oppression of women, or oil wealth (Held 2005, 3–4). Such manufactured and oversimplified geographical imaginings have not only shaped many people’s perceptions of the Middle East but also influenced material practices and political decisions (Driver 2005, 149; Haldrup, Koefoed, and Simonsen 2006; Painter 2006, 758). Since 9/11, American prejudices against Middle Easterners, Arabs, and Muslims have increased (Saad 2006), and so have reported incidents of racial/cultural profiling and hate crimes (Elias 2006; Cole 2007; Lockman 2007b; Gardner 2009). Furthermore, recent geographical imaginings of this Other as a threat to America have helped to frame and legitimize U.S. hegemonic endeavors in the Middle East (Little 2002, 10; Flint and Falah 2004; Gregory 2004; Merskin 2004; Culcasi 2006; Sparke 2007).

Focused on the role of scholars, politicians, travelers, and the mass media (Fromkin 1989; Said 1997; Steet 2000; Shaheen 2001, 2008), numerous works have critiqued the power relationships involved in the representation of the Middle East. Yet no critiques focus specifically on the creation and naturalization of this region as a geographical place. As Dona Stewart highlighted in the *Geographical Review*’s special issue on “Geographies of the Middle East” (2005a), the need for geographers to contribute a spatial perspective in understanding the post-9/11 world is great. Furthermore, Zachary Lockman, president of the Middle East Studies Association, recently wrote that “too many Americans . . . remain profoundly ignorant (or grossly misinformed)” about the Middle East (2007a), and he charges his readers with educating people about this region with which the United States is so deeply involved.

INSCRIBING AND INSTITUTIONALIZING THE TERM “MIDDLE EAST”

My essay works toward both Stewart’s and Lockman’s appeals by contributing a geographical critique of a place not only about which Americans are “misinformed” but also with which we are increasingly engaged. Because, as will become evident, the United States and Great Britain were the two countries that had the most influential roles in constructing the region, my focus is on the origins, definitions, delineations, and meanings of the region that stem from American and British data sources.²

Tracing the origins of the term “Middle East” leads directly to British imperial geopolitics of the early twentieth century. Great Britain’s possessions in South Asia made the Middle East not only a geostrategically important region but also the middle of the journey east to India; hence the term “Middle East.” From its genesis, this British-centric label referred to an ambiguous region of Asia between the Mediterranean and Indian oceans (Chirol 1902–1903). The Middle East was also considered the area between the “Far East” and the “Near East,” which were more established, though still vague, geographical terms.

Captain Alfred Mahan of the U.S. Navy is commonly credited with having coined the term “Middle East” in 1902 in reference to British imperial interests (Davison 1960; Adelson 1995, 1, 22; Held 2005, 8; Microsoft 2007). In his *National Review* article on “The Persian Gulf and International Relations,” Mahan delineated a vague territory that centered on Persia, Mesopotamia, and the Persian Gulf and then went on to inform his readers that he was the first to use the term “Middle East” to refer to this area (1902, 33, 39). Yet two years earlier, British General Thomas Edward Gordon had published an article in the journal *The Nineteenth Century* entitled “The Problem of the Middle East” (1900). Gordon did not specifically delimit or define the region, but his concern was with Afghanistan, Persia, Russia, and British India. What is interesting in Gordon’s article is the casual usage of the term “the Middle East,” which seemingly implies that it may have been commonplace in British India, where he was stationed (Koppes 1976, 96; Drysdale and Blake 1985, 10). Regardless of who was the first to use the term, it emerged at the beginning of the twentieth century in reference to British geopolitics (C. G. Smith 1968, 4).

The British journalist Valentine Chirol helped popularize the term and the idea of the Middle East in a series of letters entitled “The Middle Eastern Question,” published in the *Times of London* in 1902 and 1903. In his twenty-one letters, written as a political travelogue about his journey from Persia to India, Chirol addressed British security issues as an “Asiatic Power.” The Middle East is not defined in any of his letters; indeed, he rarely used the term, but in one of his first letters he referred to the region as having been “aptly christened” by Captain Mahan (14 October 1902). Through a careful reading of Chirol’s reports, it is clear that he was primarily concerned with a region that extended from Persia to the western border of India. Chirol considered this expansive area the “cornerstone of the British Empire,” and he believed that securing it was “most urgent . . . from an Indian point of view” (21 April 1903). Not surprisingly, an Orientalist perspective is evident in his letters, for he wrote of the backward people, their lack of advancement, and the insolent forms of government. Through the large readership of the *Times of London*, Chirol helped popularize the British-centric term “the Middle East,” but not until after World War I and British military conquests in the region did both the term and the idea of the Middle East become common in the United Kingdom.

In 1921 Winston Churchill officially institutionalized the term when he established and led the Middle East Department of the British Colonial Office. The department was concerned with British post–World War I territories in Palestine,

Transjordan, Iraq, and Egypt; thus Syria, Lebanon, the Arabian Peninsula, Turkey, and Iran were not part of his vision of the Middle East. However, this early extent of the Middle East was neither permanent nor universal. Through the mid-twentieth century the British Parliament, the Royal Air Force's Middle East Command, the British Army, and the Royal Geographical Society all used different definitions and extents of the Middle East (Loder 1923, 5–6; Davison 1960; Lee 1980; Bilgin 2000, 17).

The older and more established term “Near East” created additional confusion over both the meaning and the location of the “Middle East.”³ However, by the end of World War II the use of the term “Near East” had dwindled in the United Kingdom, and the distinction between the Middle East and the Near East eventually blurred (Lewis and Wigen 1997, 66). In 1948 the newly formed United Nations considered the Near East “dead” and defined the Middle East as stretching across three continents to include Afghanistan, Iran, Iraq, Syria, Lebanon, Turkey, Saudi Arabia, Yemen, Egypt, Ethiopia, and Greece (Davison 1960, 673). Indeed, in the early years of the cold war the term “Middle East” had completely replaced “Near East” in British official documents (Owen 2000; Bilgin 2000, 19). By the 1950s the Middle East that Alfred Mahan had defined fifty years earlier was no longer concerned with the defense of British India. The region's extent and Great Britain's geopolitical interest in it had changed to such a degree that Mahan himself might not have recognized it (Davison 1960, 673; Bilgin 2000, 19).

In the United States, use of the term “Middle East” slowly emerged during the early twentieth century. Similar to that in the United Kingdom, American usage was confused with the slightly older designation “Near East” (Lewis and Holt 1962, 1). For example, Isaiah Bowman, in his book *The New World: Problems in Political Geography* (1921), never mentioned the Middle East; instead, he referred to Palestine, Iraq, Transjordan, Constantinople, Egypt, and Syria as the “Near East.” The American delegates who negotiated peace in Paris after World War I did not use the term “Middle East” either but referred to all former Ottoman lands as “Western Asia.” In 1919, just after the World War I ended, a *National Geographic* magazine article on “The Rise of the New Arab Nation” (Simpich 1919) used the terms “Middle East” and “Near East” interchangeably (while also continually asserting the primitive status of Arabia).

Not until the cold war years did the term and the idea of the “Middle East” gain widespread acceptance in the United States. In 1957 Secretary of State John Foster Dulles declared that the Near East and the Middle East were “identical” (Davison 1960, 665). Although the term “Near East” is still used in both the United States and the United Kingdom, it is often in reference to ancient history or archeology, and it is less frequently found in the media, political speeches, or everyday parlance. Occasionally “Near East” also appears as a relic of the early twentieth century: for example, the U.S. State Department's Foreign Service established the Bureau of Near Eastern Affairs in 1909, and, although the name remains, the bureau's initiatives are all in reference to the Middle East.⁴

During the cold war, as U.S. interest and involvement in the region increased, the “Middle East” not only replaced the “Near East” semantically but also emerged in the American geopolitical imagination. The cold war period, according to Roderic Davison, saw geopolitical disputes across the region “lumped together” under the general label “Middle East” (1960, 665). As this relatively new label gained popularity, it acquired negative connotations in relation to Islamic fundamentalism and the Iranian hostage crisis, the Lebanese civil war and the bombing of a U.S. military base, and the oil crises of the 1970s, to name only a few issues. Thus, from its very origins in the American geographical imagination, the “Middle East” was constructed as a place of turmoil, crisis, and anti-Americanism.

LOCATING THE MIDDLE EAST CARTOGRAPHICALLY

One of the most effective ways to make a place real is to map it. Although maps are social constructions, they are also one of the most intellectually powerful ways to create, codify, and naturalize places (Pickles 2004; Wood and Fels 2008). Thus the construction and naturalization of the Middle East, like any place, is inextricably linked to its placement on a map. Examination of how numerous world-regional textbooks and world atlases have mapped the Middle East highlights a contradiction: Even though cartographic images have helped to create the Middle East as a real and mappable place, no consensus about its location exists.

The cartographic variations in three popular college-level world-regional geography textbooks exemplify this contradiction. Christopher Salter and Joseph Hobbs’s *Essentials of World Regional Geography* includes a map of “The Middle East and North Africa” in the chapter of the same name (2003, 222). As the map title indicates, this region includes the North African states of Morocco, Algeria, Libya, Tunisia, and Western Sahara (hereafter referred to as “North Africa”), in addition to Egypt, Sudan, Turkey, Cyprus, Syria, Iraq, Lebanon, Israel and the Occupied Territories, Jordan, Iran, and the Arabian Peninsula states of Kuwait, Saudi Arabia, Yemen, United Arab Emirates, Oman, Bahrain, Qatar (hereafter referred to as “the Arabian Peninsula”), and Afghanistan. *World Regions in Global Context, Peoples, Places and Environment*, by Sallie Marston, Paul Knox, and Diana Liverman (2002), differs slightly from Salter and Hobbs’s textbook. In their chapter titled “The Middle East and North Africa,” Marston, Know, and Liverman exclude Afghanistan and Cyprus from their cartographic definition. In Harm de Blij, Peter Muller, and Antoinette WinklerPrins’s *The World Today: Concepts and Regions in Geography*, a map of the “Middle East” is included in the chapter on “North Africa / Southwest Asia” (2009, 251). This map delineates the smallest extent of the region I located in any source, for it includes only Iraq, Syria, Jordan, Lebanon, and Israel and the Occupied Territories.

Like world-regional textbooks, world atlases reflect and create ambiguity while making the region seem quite real. Most world atlases are organized by continent, so maps of the Middle East are generally included in chapters on Asia.⁵ Inclusion of the Middle East as part of Asia led to some notable eastward expansions of the

region toward China and some creative treatments of Egypt in Africa. It also meant that North Africa west of Egypt were generally excluded from the Middle East.

Although some atlases clearly define the region in their table of contents, in associated text, or by cartographically shading or outlining specific states, many representations are less explicit. For example, *Goode's World Atlas* map of the Middle East centers on Egypt, the Arabian Peninsula, Iraq, Iran, Jordan, Israel and the Occupied Territories, Lebanon, Syria, and Cyprus (Veregin 2005, 200–201). However, whether Libya, Sudan, Chad, Eritrea, Ethiopia, Somalia, Djibouti, Turkey, Afghanistan, Pakistan, Turkmenistan, Armenia, and Azerbaijan are part of the region is less clear. Some of these states break through the margin and run off the map, but the fact that they are shown only in part creates some speculation about their inclusion in the region.

Changes in several editions of *The Times Atlas of the World*, one of Great Britain's most established, creates even more ambiguity.⁶ In a 1985 edition, a 1:15,000,000 map titled "Middle East: Asia, South" spans an area from Yugoslavia in the northwest, to Tanzania in the southwest, to Singapore in the southeast, and to Mongolia in the northeast. Although the focus is clearly on Asia, Egypt is unquestionably included in this region, for its western border is extended over the map's margin to protrude from Africa. Twelve years earlier, in the 1973 edition, the same map had been entitled "Indo-Arabia," thus indicating that the term "Middle East" had become more common in the 1980s. The map of "Middle East: Asia, South" was also present in the 1992 ninth edition, but in the 1999 tenth edition it was replaced with an 1:9,000,000 map of "Southwest Asia," which centered on Saudi Arabia, Iraq, and Iran, and reached northeastward to China, southeastward to India, westward to Turkey, and southward to Sudan.

The 1999 seventh edition of the *Atlas of the World* published by the National Geographic Society (NGS) again demonstrates the vagueness of locating the region by including both a map of "Southwest Asia" and one of the "Middle East" (the former having a larger eastward scope). The map of the Middle East had undefined boundaries but included all of Cyprus, Turkey, Syria, Israel and the Occupied Territories, Lebanon, Jordan, Iraq, Kuwait, Qatar, and Bahrain. Most of Iran and Egypt, and half of Saudi Arabia, were within its scope. No portions of Yemen, Oman, or the United Arab Emirates are shown, but Greece, Azerbaijan, Georgia, Russia, and Turkmenistan are partially visible, and Armenia and Azerbaijan are included in their entirety. The 2004 eighth edition of the NGS *Atlas of the World* contains some noteworthy alterations. The focus of the Middle East shifted slightly northward, so that more of Russia and Bulgaria are on the map, all of Georgia is visible, and a part of Kazakhstan shows. In the south, less of Egypt, Qatar, and Saudi Arabia fall within the map's scope. What is peculiar about this edition, however, is a caption placed in the Mediterranean Sea: "Turkey, Cyprus, Syria, Lebanon, Israel, Jordan, Egypt, Iraq, Iran, and the countries of the Arabian Peninsula form the heart of the Middle East region" (NGS 2004, 73). Although this statement seemingly serves to definitively delimit the "heart" of the region, further confusion is created from the description in

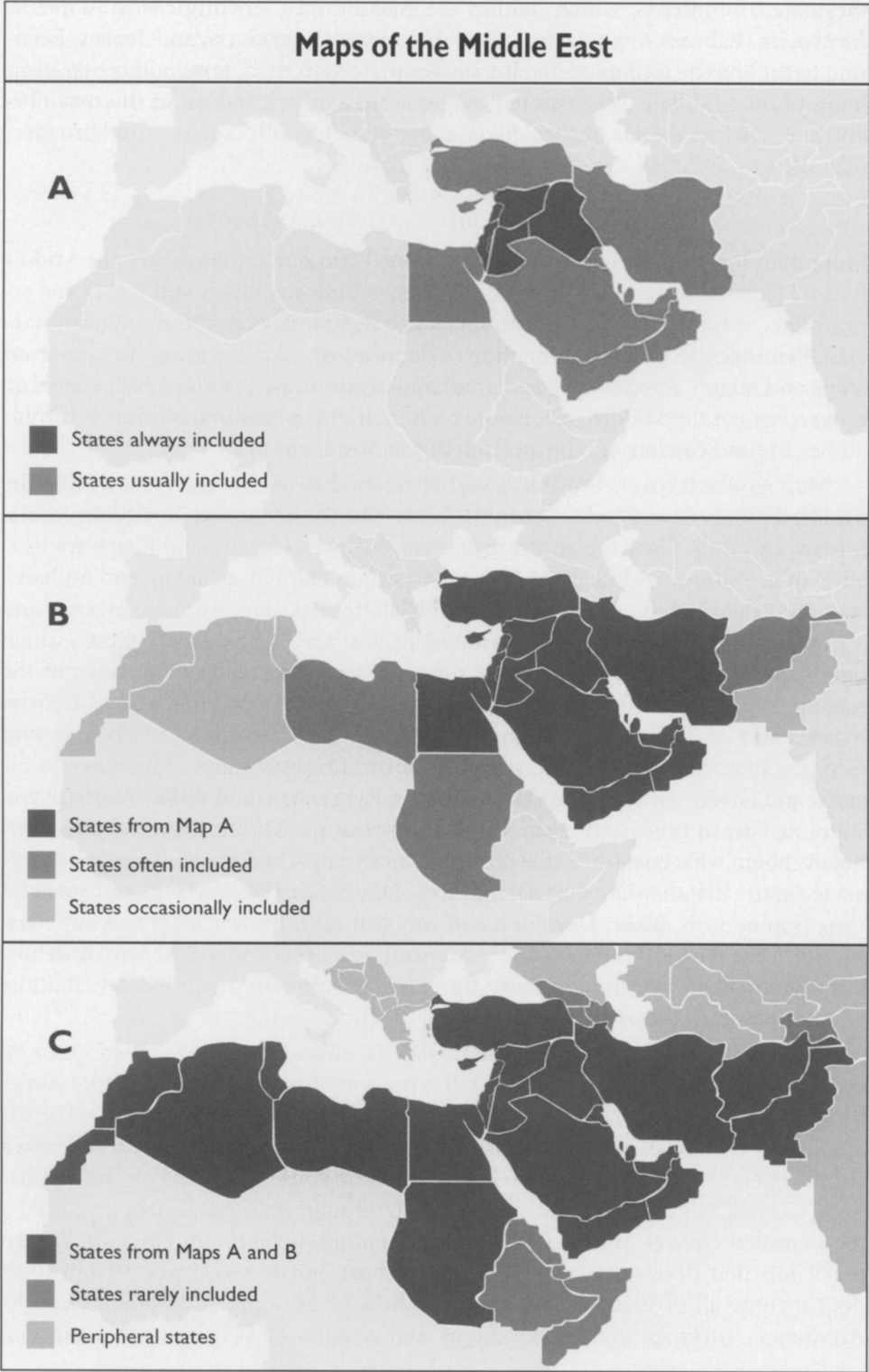
the table of contents, which defines the Middle East as comprising Armenia, Azerbaijan, Bahrain, Georgia, Iraq, Jordan, Kuwait, Qatar, Syria, and Turkey. Referring to the “heart” of the region also alludes to a relatively common idea that some states of the Middle East are more peripheral than others. Indeed, as discussed below, the 2003 NGS *Atlas of the Middle East* refers to both “focus” and “broader” regions.

SUMMARIZING THE GEOGRAPHICAL AMBIGUITY

More than forty years ago Davison commented “no one knows where the Middle East is” (1960, 665), and, as the examples above indicate, this is still true. Even so, regardless of how tenuous delineations of the region may be, some similarities do exist. Stemming from my examination of definitions and delineations in numerous maps and atlases, government and academic institutions, and from historians and geographers of the Middle East, Figure 1 summarizes the commonalities and ambiguities I found concerning the location of the Middle East.

Map A, which covers the area hereafter referred to as the “core,” shows that the Middle East always includes Lebanon, Israel and the Occupied Territories, Syria, Jordan, and Iraq. The Arabian Peninsula, Iran, Turkey, Cyprus, and Egypt are usually, but not always, included.⁷ Map B demonstrates that Libya, Sudan, and Afghanistan are often included, whereas Western Sahara, Pakistan, Tunisia, Algeria, and Morocco are only occasionally considered part of the Middle East. Map C, which builds on Map A and Map B, points out that definitions and delineations of the region rarely include Eritrea, Djibouti, Somalia, and Ethiopia, as well as Central Asian states of Turkmenistan, Tajikistan, Armenia, Uzbekistan, Azerbaijan, and Georgia; nevertheless, they do appear. Eastern European states—Yugoslavia, Bulgaria, and Greece—Russia, China, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and India are peripheral states that are at times within the scope of maps of the Middle East. Although ambiguity about what constitutes the region certainly exists, and many atlases and scholars recognize that there is no clear definition of the region (Powell, Geib, and Spengler 1975; Bonine 1976; Blake, Dewdney, and Mitchell 1987; Brawer 1988; Sidaway 1994; Marston, Knox, and Liverman 2002; Marston and others 2011), the varied definitions and delineations used to make this series of summary maps indicate that the region does indeed exist.

The difficulty in locating the Middle East is reflected in the recent adoption of the term “Greater Middle East,” which has been used sporadically to denote something beyond a heart or focus region (see Whitaker 2004; Stewart 2005b). For example, the George W. Bush administration adopted this label in 2004 to refer to a region extending from Morocco to Pakistan. Yet no consensus exists on the expanse of a “Greater Middle East” either. In 2002 Hammond map publishers produced a map entitled *Greater Middle East Region, including Afghanistan, Pakistan, Turkey, and Libya* that does not cartographically include North Africa west of Libya yet does include all of Eritrea, Djibouti, and slices of Ethiopia and Sudan. Georgia, Azerbaijan, Turkmenistan, Tajikistan, as well as parts of Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan,



Kyrgyzstan, and China are also within the map's scope. Similarly, the NGS *Atlas of the Middle East* contains a focus region that includes Turkey, Syria, Cyprus, Lebanon, Israel and the Occupied Territories, Egypt, Jordan, Iraq, Iran, and the Arabian Peninsula (2003). The atlas also recognizes a broader delineation of the region in which Morocco, Western Sahara, Algeria, Libya, Sudan, Afghanistan, Pakistan, and Tajikistan are added to the focus states. The broader Middle East, as clarified in the atlas, is a term "used in a cultural sense to describe lands in southwest Asia and that are predominately Islamic" (p. 10). Indeed, defining the Middle East as a world region generally necessitates references to cultural criteria.

DEFINING CHARACTERISTICS OF THE MIDDLE EAST

The term "Middle East" often conjures up images of a timeless, violent, and even mysterious place. The geographers Ian Manners and Barbara Parmenter referred to "a camel caravan crossing desert dunes, oil derricks pumping thin black crude, rows of men kneeling in prayer, [and] bearded protesters shouting slogans" as examples of widely held images of the Middle East (2008, 9). Numerous sources cite an Arab/Islamic culture as the dominant unifying factor of the Middle East (see Bulut 1997; Khalidi 1998; NGS 2003, 10; Microsoft 2007). However, such a trait not only ignores non-Arab/Muslims living in the region but also potentially merges these two distinct cultural traits into one uniform characteristic.

At first glimpse the ethnic/linguistic identifier "Arab" may seem to be a reasonable trait with which to define the Middle East, for many of the countries considered part of the Middle East "core" have Arab majorities. Ethnicity and language have played a role in defining some world regions—"Latin America," for example—yet such traits facilitate the essentialization of places. Even though a strong Arab identity is present in many of the "core" Middle Eastern countries, the Arab ethnic/linguistic identifier is problematic for several reasons. Most obvious is that it excludes the non-Arab states of Israel, Turkey, and Iran, which are almost always considered part of the Middle East. Defining the Middle East as Arab also ignores large non-Arab populations such as the Kurds and Berbers, who reside in many different countries. Furthermore, although many states in the Middle East have an Arab majority, an Arab identity does not unify them. Arabs from Morocco to Egypt to Iraq differ immensely in their history, local practices, and dialects. Political schisms have also been common between Arab-majority states. One of the most divisive of these schisms was Iraq's 1990 invasion of the fellow Arab state of Kuwait. From the

FIG. 1 (*facing page*)—These three maps show the regularity and variance of states that are considered part of the Middle East. Map A shows the most common delineations (the "core"): Israel and the Occupied Territories, Jordan, Syria, Lebanon, and Iraq are always included; the neighboring states are usually included. Maps B and C build on Map A by adding states that are included less often. Map B shows that the region often includes Libya, Sudan, and Afghanistan; whereas Algeria, Tunisia, and Morocco are occasionally included as a group, and Western Sahara and Pakistan are occasionally included but with little pattern. Map C shows the most inclusive delineations: East African states, some Caucasus states, and Tajikistan appear on rare occasions, and even states in Eastern Europe, Central Asia, India, China, and Russia are sometimes considered within the scope of the Middle East. (Cartography by the author)

late 1950s until the early 1970s the Arab nationalist movement began to unify Arabs across international borders, but the movement waned, and today Arab states have developed their own national identities. Therefore, to stress the Arab character of the Middle East is to ignore immense diversity in the region, both between Arabs and between all other ethnic/linguist groups.

The events of 9/11 and the heightened fear of Islamic fundamentalism have affected the boundaries and defining traits of the Middle East. Countries such as Afghanistan and Pakistan, which have literally been at the margins of the Middle East, are now more regularly included as part of the region (Stewart 2005a). As mentioned above, the *Atlas of the Middle East's* "broader" definition is characterized by the predominance of Islam (NGS 2003, 10). *Microsoft Encarta* also used the same Islamic qualification to define a "broader" Middle East that extended from Morocco to Pakistan (2007). Even though Islam is the predominant religion of most of the "core" Middle Eastern states, Islamic-based definitions of the Middle East exclude Indonesia, India, Pakistan, and Bangladesh, which contain the largest Muslim populations in the world. Furthermore, the contiguous Muslim countries of Mauritania and Somalia are generally not included in any definitions of the Middle East. Contrary to many essentialized images of Islam in the West, great diversity is found among Muslims. This includes not only the main division between Shi'a and Sunni Muslims and the different official schools of thought within those divisions but also the countless interpretations of Islam that vary from person to person. Moreover, the many non-Muslim groups in the Middle East, such as Christian Copts, Jews, Zoroastrians, Bahá'ís, Druze, and Maronite Christians are marginalized in an Islamic definition.

The historian Nikki Keddie suggested that the perceived connection between the Middle East and Islam exists because historically the Middle East is where Islam emerged and spread (1973, 257); and indeed, the borders of the "core" region roughly correspond to the Islamic empires of the Umayyad, the Abbasid, and the Ottomans. Although these Islamic empires were immensely influential throughout the region, their territories were extensive and included extremely diverse peoples and cultures.

The Middle East is often understood in historical terms that are broader than just the major Islamic empires. Based on the existence of ancient civilizations and the fact that Judaism, Christianity, and Islam all originated there, Bernard Lewis and Peter Holt argued that the Middle East is "an area with an unmistakable character and historic identity" (1962, 2–3). However, the region has no singular historical legacy. Ancient realms such as the Egyptian, Persian, Seleucid, Roman, Byzantine, and Sassanian empires, as well as Ptolemaic, Chaldean, Assyrian, Babylonian, Phoenician and Hittite civilizations, all had varying degrees of control in different parts of the region. More recent history does not define the region either. Although European imperialism was a major factor in much of the "core" region during the twentieth century, its extent and impacts were varied.

Moreover, the region cannot be aptly defined as economically or politically coherent. A huge gap in development and social services exists between the oil-rich

states of the Persian Gulf and the less-resource-wealthy states of Lebanon, Israel, Syria, Jordan, and North Africa. Even within each country differences between the poor and the wealthy are striking. Some states, particularly Turkey and Israel, have embraced capitalist free-market economies; others have attempted to maintain nationalists/socialist systems. Although democracy is less prevalent in the Middle East than in Europe, and despite the George W. Bush administration's characterization of the region as states that "all lack democracy" (Held 2005, 10), several states, such as Turkey, Egypt, Iraq, and Israel, are ostensibly democratic. Regional political alliances also vary immensely among Middle Eastern states, and such political differences have culminated in numerous interregional feuds and wars. Yet even though political schisms exist among many of the predominately Arab countries, mutual disdain for Israel and U.S. interventions in the region creates some uniformity (C. G. Smith 1968, 14; Keddie 1973, 256; Luciani and Salamé 1988, 25; Sayigh 1991; Whitaker and Varghese 2009).

Physical geography cannot define this region either. Often depicted as barren, much of the Middle East is indeed a desert, but water resources vary greatly, from the relatively bountiful Nile and Tigris/Euphrates river basins and Beirut's 35 inches of rainfall a year (which is 12 inches more than London) to the arid Arabian and Syrian deserts (Lewis and Wigen 1997, 184). Physical features such as rivers, seas, and mountains often create borders, but, considering the numerous delineations of the Middle East, natural features cannot define the region. Nearly all definitions and delineations have the region spanning two continents. Although the labels "Southwest Asia" and "Swasia" have been adopted sporadically as non-Eurocentric alternatives to "Middle East" (Cressey 1960, 9), Egypt's location in Africa clearly challenges the utility of a label that pertains only to the Asian continent.

The reason it is difficult to define the region culturally, historically, economically, politically, or physically is the absence of uniform characteristics that world regions ostensibly maintain. At local, national, and regional scales, great diversity exists in the Middle East, and, as Keddie argued, the countries of the region "show more diversity than unity" (1962, 256). Many Americans may imagine the region as having generalized cultural or historical traits, but with a little probing the inconsistencies and contradictions in these common defining characteristics are easily revealed.

IMPLICATIONS

In this essay I showed that the Middle East has been constructed and naturalized as a specific geographical place through the creation and institutionalization of the term "Middle East," the vague but nevertheless continued delineations of its geographical existence, and the oversimplification of the traits that are used to define the region. The sources I used to elucidate the region's construction were diverse, but together they showed that, even though the Middle East is a Western geopolitical construction that cannot be definitively located, the region frequently invokes oversimplified connotations and imaginings.

Although the idea of the “Middle East” and use of the term are ubiquitous in the United States, neither has been uniformly adopted across the globe; rather, from within the Western-defined Middle East the term has been implemented only sporadically and hesitantly. When it is used, it is generally in a geopolitical context relating either to Western oil interests or to Arab-Israeli conflicts (Khalidi 1998, 74; Bilgin 2000; Manners and Parmenter 2008, 12–13; Culcasi 2007, 335). Furthermore, in Arab countries such as Egypt, Jordan, or Libya, the regional designation “Arab World” and “Arab Homeland” are much more common and meaningful than is the “Middle East” (Culcasi 2007).

Dividing the world in discrete regions that are theoretically unified by human and physical geographical traits is a commonly accepted way in which to order and understand our world. Whether we are referring to “Western Europe,” “Southeast Asia,” or the “Middle East,” all world regions have been created, imagined, and naturalized through various historical, economic, and political discourses. What is unique about the Middle East is that pejorative discourses about this place are widespread and readily accepted. As the media scholar Jack Shaheen shows through his comprehensive analyses of media representations (2008), Arabs, Muslims, and Middle Easterners are today subjected to derogatory and racist stereotypes that would be considered unacceptable for other groups, such as Asians, blacks, Jews, or Hispanics. Much of the reason for the persistent and seemingly acceptable stereotypes of the Middle East is political. Imagining the Orient as an inferior and backward place has helped to justify Western geopolitical ambitions in the region for centuries. And today, the Othering of the Middle East has helped to legitimize U.S. foreign policies in that region.

As both Brian Whitaker’s quip in the epigraph and my comparative analysis clearly show, even though no one knows where the Middle East is, this place is part of our everyday geographies. Our complacent acceptance not merely of the region’s existence but also of its fundamental separation from “us” has made us prisoners of our own geographical imaginations. Critiquing the foundational myths of the region—its Western geopolitical origins, its tenuous extent, and the common characteristics used to define it—provides an essential component for critically examining our everyday, taken-for-granted imaginings of the region. Since 9/11 and the increased involvement of the United States in the region, it is now more crucial than ever to critically examine our oversimplified notions of the Middle East.

NOTES

1. The first time I use the terms “Middle East,” “West,” “Near East,” and “Orient” in this essay I enclose them with quotation marks as a reminder of their tenuous definitions and locations, but thereafter I do not, except when I refer to them as terms.

2. The findings I present draw on data I gleaned from three U.S. college-level textbooks, twelve world atlases, six Middle East regional atlases, and several flat maps, as well as from eleven Middle Eastern historians and five geographers, from government institutions in the United States, the United Kingdom, and the United Nations, from political and military leaders, and from numerous encyclopedias, library cataloging systems, and professional and academic institutions in the United States and the United Kingdom.

3. The term "Near East," which became a part of popular discourse in Europe in the late nineteenth century (Davison 1960, 666), generally extended from Mesopotamia to India (Keddie 1973, 267). But it also occasionally stretched westward to the Balkans, Greece, and North Africa. In other instances, the term referred to the Levant, Turkey, or the Ottoman Empire (for further discussion, see C. G. Smith 1968; Koppes 1976, 95; Lewis and Wigen 1997, 65–66; Whitaker 2004).
4. For explicit references to the Middle East—which covers Algeria, Bahrain, Egypt, Iran, Iraq, Israel, Jordan, Kuwait, Lebanon, Libya, Morocco, Oman, Palestinian Territories, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, Syria, Tunisia, United Arab Emirates, and Yemen—see U.S. Department of State 2010.
5. Not surprisingly, world atlases include differently scaled maps of many different regions of the world. Common maps that included much of what is also considered part of the Middle East are: "Eastern Mediterranean," "Southwest Asia," "North Africa," the "Gulf States," and the "Arabian Peninsula."
6. I examined six editions (from 1955 to 2003) of *The Times Atlas of the World*, and not until 1973 did a world-regional designation that resembled anything similar to the Middle East appear. The 2003 edition has the same maps as the 1999 edition.
7. As discussed above, de Blij, Muller, and WinklerPrins's map of the "Middle East" only includes Iraq, Jordan, Syria, Lebanon, and Israel and the Occupied Territories (2009, 251); and the 1999 NGS *Atlas of the World* cuts off the southern half of the Arabian Peninsula (1999, 97–98).

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